

Saint Cyril of Alexandria

Homily 11

HOMILY 11

Encomium on Holy Mary, Mother of God.

Our discourse is splendid and full of grace, all the more since the assembly of the holy Fathers is itself illustrious. For when my soul was afflicted with intense grief because of the impious blasphemy of Nestorius, I stirred up this resounding, beautiful, angelic, and heavenly chorus. These are the teachers of piety, the pillars and summits of faith, those unshaken towers, harbors of gladness, faithful and prudent stewards, wise architects, who live the heavenly voyage and the angelic life on earth, the companions of the prophets, the colleagues of the apostles, and the bishops of the holy churches, the avengers of wicked blasphemy, the wise defenders of our poverty—nay, rather, of our name. These who occupy the beautiful and godlike throne of the high priesthood, who distil mellifluous streams, who are spiritual heralds of divine understanding, who have traversed the four-parted world with tireless pilgrimage—whom neither heat, nor storms at sea, nor the untamed fury of raging waves, nor tempestuous gales kept from coming here among the faithful with exultant steps; but having cast aside all sloth, impelled not merely by desire but rather by fear of the Lord, and having taken up the cross as wise vindicators of Mary the Mother of God, they have assembled here. Wherefore, strengthened by their holy prayers, let us rejoice a little for this city, and so I shall turn my address to the praises of the Mother of God. Hail, city of the Ephesians, made

fairer by a new outlook upon the sea, because in place of earthly harbors angelic and heavenly harbors have come to you. Hail, glory of the province of Asia, because you are built on every side with temples of saints like precious pearls, and now you are also hallowed by the footsteps of many holy Fathers and patriarchs. For the very gates, streets, and harbors are truly blessed by the coming of the holy Fathers. For where many shepherds assemble, through them a great gathering of holiness is made; but above all these religious, faithful men, equal to the angels, drive out all satanic power and pagan idolatry—that of the Porphyrians and Sabellians, Phrygians, Apollinarists, and Photinians—and through them, to speak in a word, every wicked heresy is put to confusion, while the glory of the orthodox faith is celebrated. Hail also, O thrice-blessed John, apostle and evangelist, ornament of virginity, teacher of chastity, destroyer of diabolical deceit, overthrower of the temple of Diana, harbor and bulwark of the city of Ephesus, nourisher of the poor, refuge of the afflicted, rest and refreshment of neighbors and strangers. Hail, most pure vessel full of temperance. For to you, when our Lord Jesus Christ was carried upon the cross, he entrusted that God-bearing ever-Virgin to you, the virgin disciple. Hail also to you, Mary, Mother of God, virgin mother, bearer of light, incorruptible vessel. Hail, Virgin Mary, mother and handmaid: Virgin indeed, because of him who was born from you, a Virgin; but mother, because of him whom you bore in your arms and nursed with your milk; handmaid, because of him who took the form of a servant. For the King entered your city—or rather, your womb—and went forth again as he willed, and your gate was shut. For you conceived without seed and brought forth by divine power. Hail,

Mary, temple in which God is received—nay, holy temple, as the prophet David cries aloud, saying: Holy is your temple, wonderful in righteousness (Psalm 64:5–6). Hail, Mary, most precious possession of the whole world; hail, Mary, incorruptible dove; hail, Mary, lamp unquenchable: for from you was born the Sun of righteousness. Hail, Mary, dwelling-place of him who is not contained by place, you who received God the only-begotten Word, you who brought forth the ear of grain without plow and without seed, unfading. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, for whom the prophets cry out, for whom the shepherds sing praises to God with the angels, uttering that awesome hymn: Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace to people of good will (Luke 2:14). Hail, Mary, Mother of God, for whom the angels lead the choirs; the archangels exult, sending forth awesome hymns. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, for whom the Magi adore, led by the bright star. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, for whom was chosen the glory of the twelve apostles. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, for whom John, while still in his mother's womb, leaped up and adored the everlasting Light, the lamp that never fails. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom ineffable grace appeared, of which the Apostle said: The grace of God that brings salvation has appeared to all men (Titus 2:11). Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom the true light appeared, our Lord Jesus Christ, who says in the Gospels: I am the light of the world (John 8:12). Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom light has shone upon those who sit in darkness and the shadow of death. For the people, he says, who sat in darkness have seen a great light (Isaiah 9:2). What light, if not our Lord Jesus Christ, that true light which enlightens every man coming into this world? Hail, Mary,

Mother of God, for whom it is preached in the Gospels: Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord (Psalm 118:26); for whom in cities, villages, and islands orthodox churches have been founded. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom appeared the conqueror of death and the destroyer of hell. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom appeared the maker of the first-formed man and the healer of his transgression, the leader of the heavenly kingdom. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom the glory of the resurrection flourished and shone forth. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom the awe-inspiring baptism of holiness at the Jordan shone forth. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom John and the Jordan are sanctified, and the devil is cast out. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, through whom every faithful spirit is saved. Hail, Mary, Mother of God, for through you the waves of the sea, calmed and stilled, bore our fellow servants and fellow ministers with joy and gentleness. For the land, once held by brigands, was turned to peace by the coming of the holy Fathers. For it is written: How beautiful are the feet of those who preach peace (Isaiah 52:7)! What peace, if not our Lord Jesus Christ, the herald of peace, who says in the holy Gospels: My peace I give to you (John 14:27). What peace? That which the blasphemer Nestorius did not accept, saying that our Lord Jesus Christ, God's Son, the Word, was not born of the Virgin Mary, neither acknowledging the inviolable childbirth of virginity, nor believing the voice of the archangel who said: Hail, full of grace, the Lord is with you (Luke 1:28). For, likened to the Persian tyrant, and attempting to strip the only-begotten Son of God of his divinity, he devised these things to the ruin of many and the blasphemy of souls.

But since I spoke at length yesterday of this rooster that blasphemed wickedly, when I explained to you the partridge which the prophet Jeremiah proclaimed, saying: The partridge has cried out: she has gathered what she did not hatch (Jeremiah 17:11)—this wicked blasphemer too, seeing himself defended by his courtiers, was puffed up by their support; nay, when he hoped to strike terror into us, he only roused us. Come, let us say with sighs and tears, as is our custom: It is good to trust in the Lord, rather than to trust in princes (Psalm 117:9). For this man—this accursed one—having emptied his golden quiver, has stirred up consuls and companions, the masters of the court, and the choir of queens; but let us take up that prophetic word: Some trust in chariots, and some in horses: but we will call upon the name of the Lord our God (Psalm 19:8). For if I must speak either to the powers of the world or to the most pious emperor, I shall not be put to shame nor afraid, since I have the prophet David ever at my side, urging me on and saying: I spoke in the sight of kings, and I was not ashamed (Psalm 118:46). Who has heard things so horrible and dreadful? Christ, God the Word, preached to us by the prophets and apostles, is now transformed into a mere man, and the God-bearer is called man's equal! Let no one charge me now with the shameless audacity of the ungrateful, wicked Jews, which the impious used against Christ in those days. For who has given him confidence now? He who assailed the word of God with blasphemous speech, saying: You crucified a man. Yes—and the error of the Gentiles, impious incense, and abominable sacrifices offered to stones; the wicked schemes and foul disease of Arius; the most criminal blasphemy of the Manichees; the pestilent counsel of Sabellius, Porphyry, and

Photinus, whom he follows here as well in blaspheming—alas! At last this man's wickedness has surpassed them all, and the saying of that proud head has been fulfilled in him: I will pull down my barns, and build greater (Luke 12:18). To whom it was answered: You fool, this night they will demand your soul from you (Luke 12:20): and the things you have prepared, whose will they be? For as high as you were lifted up—you who were filth, born of a filthy line—so far have you been cast down in turn and hurled into the pit of blasphemy: you whom Paul the apostle did not convert, that chosen vessel, the living voice of the Church, the evangelical and heavenly fire, the fragrant fountain, the bearer and writer of the Epistles, who, though deprived of sight on the road, penetrated the highest heavens by knowledge of God, whom the vision of Christ threw to the ground, and the knowledge of God led back to faith; who taught the world to believe in the consubstantial Trinity, in one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one Father, one Son, one Holy Spirit—an undivided substance, a most simple, incomprehensible Godhead, God from God, Lord, light from light, splendor of glory, born of the Virgin Mary, according to the archangel's voice: Hail, full of grace, the Lord is with you (Luke 1:28). And again: The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore also the child born of you will be called holy, the Son of God (Luke 1:35). We hear him proclaimed not only through Gabriel the archangel, but daily in the churches through blessed David, singing and saying: The Lord said to me: You are my Son; today I have begotten you (Psalm 2:7). And that wisest Isaiah, son of Amos the prophet, a prophet from among prophets, preached, saying: Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and his name shall

be called Emmanuel, which means, God with us (Isaiah 7:14). Yet you do not believe the prophets, the apostles, or Gabriel the archangel: at least imitate your fellow-demons, who were terrified at his power and cried: What have we to do with you, Jesus, Son of God? Have you come here to torment us before the time (Matthew 8:29)? For if the demon spoke truly then when he said, before the time, now at last his words have caught up with you. For Antichrist had to come; but you have come straightway in his place; nor did you disbelieve the devil who deceives you, saying: If you are the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread (Matthew 4:3). O deed tremendous and full of astonishment! The demons, with their father the devil, call Son of God him who was born of Mary the Virgin; but Nestorius turns the Son of God into a mere man, and by a foolishly imagined change attempted to pervert the most pious emperor, servant and friend of the orthodox faith, together with the choir of holy queens illustrious in faith—yet his plot came to nothing. For he lavished the resources of the poor upon men greedy for gold, hoping truth might be stormed by their aid; and through greed of wicked gain he suffered shipwreck in the deepest misery: though he was in harbor, he made shipwreck, having cast away faith's anchor. Thus he was drowned in evils and became a tragic spectacle for the whole world. He hoped that by his malignant, burning wit he would win over the worshippers of piety, though his darkened mind could not grasp the doctrine of the Fathers, the apostles, the evangelists, or the archangels' voices; having found folly and wicked madness, and being steeped in impiety, he tried to set up a pestilent, godless religion over the whole earth. But he did not find us unprepared for his impious,

blasphemous scheme. We do not trust in military arms or a gleaming, showy guard, but answer him with the holy, divinely inspired Scriptures set against him. For our weapons are not carnal or earthly, but spiritual and heavenly, as blessed Paul taught. Yet let no one suppose that we rejoice in your fall, O most wretched man! When you fell into this pit of blasphemy, we stretched out a hand to you in letters; you despised our lowliness, and so ran into the peril of rebellion. That the matter stands thus we offer a weighty witness: the most holy Celestine, archbishop of the whole world (ἀρχιεπίσκοπον πάσης τῆς οἰκουμένης), father and patriarch of the great city of Rome, who himself urged you by letter to desist from that mad blasphemy of yours—but you would not obey even him, and gloried in the vanity of your folly; made a scourge to the whole world, you disturbed the four-parted earth and drove all the saints here with much toil and fear. You have written wickedness, not good. Therefore God will at length remove you from the priesthood and cast you out from the wisdom of the Fathers—first from the royal city, then from the throne of the high priesthood which you attained without merit. Therefore the just shall see, and fear, and laugh at you, and say: Behold the man who did not make God his helper, but trusted in the abundance of his riches, and prevailed in his vanity (Psalm 51:9). But we, as many as follow the truth of the Gospel, shall be, as the Prophet says, like a fruitful olive tree in the house of God (Psalm 51:10), glorifying God the Father almighty, and his only-begotten Son born of Mary, and the Holy Spirit, the life-giver who bestows life on all; subject to the most faithful emperors, and honoring the holy queens renowned for virginity; and we shall pray for the son of the empress, that the reign may remain

devout toward God, loving the faith and orthodox, in Christ Jesus our Lord, to whom be glory for ever and ever. Amen.